

WASC-Aligned Policy Handbook

CyberSafety, Digital Citizenship, and Responsible AI & Technology Use

WASC Accreditation Alignment Notice:

This handbook aligns directly with Western Association of Schools and Colleges (WASC) criteria regarding **School Culture, Curriculum & Instruction, Support for Student Personal and Academic Growth**, and **Resource Management**. It establishes actionable standards for maintaining a safe, ethical, equitable, and forward-thinking digital learning environment.

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1. Purpose

The purpose of this handbook is to establish a comprehensive, educational, and legally sound framework for digital safety, responsible citizenship, and technology integration across all school programs. Aligned with WASC accreditation standards, this policy ensures technology serves as an instrument for academic excellence, creative innovation, and ethical engagement while mitigating digital risks and safeguarding student well-being.

2. Scope

This policy governs all digital interactions, cloud services, LMS platforms, virtual classrooms, and official communication channels used across the online school. It applies to all hardware, home network activity during school hours, and off-platform interactions that impact the virtual community.

3. Policy Statement

The school is committed to fostering an innovative, safe, and ethically grounded learning community. We believe access to technology and Artificial Intelligence (AI) is a privilege accompanied by significant responsibility. The institution will actively cultivate digital citizenship, mandate stringent cyber safety measures, protect privacy, and enforce clear standards for acceptable and academic AI usage across all physical and virtual learning environments.

4. Objectives

- **Safe Learning Environment:** Maintain a secure cloud-based technological infrastructure that protects users from online harm, data breaches, and unvetted digital interactions.
- **Ethical AI Integration:** Provide clear guidelines for instructional and administrative use of Generative AI, emphasizing academic integrity, critical evaluation, and transparent attribution in remote coursework.
- **Digital Citizenship Education:** Embed digital literacy, cyber hygiene, and online ethical behavior across the K–12 virtual curriculum in accordance with institutional learning goals.

- **Data Protection & Privacy:** Maintain rigorous institutional standards for safeguarding student and staff personal data, ensuring privacy across virtual classrooms and home learning environments.
 - **Digital Wellbeing:** Support the physical, cognitive, and social-emotional health of remote learners through balanced online scheduling and structured off-screen practices.
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5. Guiding Principles

1. **Integrity First:** Honesty, transparency, and respect for intellectual property guide all digital creation and academic inquiry.
 2. **Safety and Respect:** Every community member deserves a digital space free from harassment, discrimination, and cyberbullying.
 3. **Equitable Access:** Technology tools and digital literacy instruction will be accessible to support diverse learner needs.
 4. **Proactive Learning:** Emphasize positive digital engagement, critical thinking, and restorative accountability over purely punitive measures.
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6. Roles and Responsibilities

Role	Key Responsibilities	Email Ids
Governing Board & Leadership	Approve digital policy framework; allocate resources for cyber safety infrastructure, security, and professional development.	
School Administration	Oversee policy implementation; investigate reported incidents; ensure ongoing WASC alignment and compliance reporting.	
IT Department	Maintain firewalls, endpoint security, content filtering, data encryption, access controls, and network monitoring systems.	
Educators & Staff	Model ethical technology/AI use; teach digital citizenship lessons; supervise online student activity;	

	enforce academic integrity guidelines.	
Students	Adhere to acceptable use standards; practice safe digital habits; cite AI/digital sources accurately; report cyber threats or bullying immediately.	
Parents & Guardians	Partner with the school to reinforce digital safety and healthy screen time habits at home; monitor home network usage.	

7. Cyber Safety Framework

The school employs a multi-layered cyber safety defense model based on international cybersecurity standards:

- **Content Filtering & Network Firewalls:** Automated real-time filtering to block malicious websites, explicit content, and unsecured domains across all campus networks.
- **Identity & Access Management (IAM):** Two-factor authentication required for staff access; secure, role-based single sign-on (SSO) for students. Only admins can reset the passwords.
- **Endpoint Safeguards:** Managed antivirus, automated security patching, and restricted administrative privileges on school-issued hardware.
- **Incident Response Plan:** Protocols for immediate containment, threat eradication, system recovery, and stakeholder communication during network breaches.

8. Digital Citizenship

Digital citizenship is integrated into the school's core curriculum, focusing on five key competency areas:

1. **Digital Identity & Footprint:** Understanding the permanence of online actions and building a positive digital reputation.
2. **Media & Information Literacy:** Evaluating online content critically, recognizing misinformation, and cross-checking sources.
3. **Digital Ethics & Copyright:** Respecting intellectual property, fair use doctrine, licensing, and proper attribution formats.

4. **Communication & Respect:** Practicing constructive, empathetic communication across online forums and collaborative platforms.
5. **Cyber Hygiene:** Creating robust passwords, recognizing phishing attempts, and safeguarding personal data.

9. Responsible Use of Artificial Intelligence

Generative AI tools (such as large language models, image generators, and automated analytical platforms) are recognized as transformative educational technologies. The school adopts a balanced approach promoting AI literacy alongside rigorous academic standards.

Permitted Uses

- Brainstorming research questions, project ideas, and outline structures (when permitted by teacher guidance).
- Grammar refinement, language learning support, and personalized tutoring assistance.
- Teacher-guided exploration of algorithmic bias, prompt engineering, and technology ethics.

Academic Integrity & AI Disclosures

- **Explicit Guidance:** Students must follow course-specific and assignment-specific AI usage levels set by teachers (e.g., *No AI*, *AI for Brainstorming Only*, *Full AI Collaboration*).
- **Required Attribution:** Any AI-generated text, image, code, or idea incorporated into student work must be explicitly cited using standard citation styles (APA, MLA, or Chicago) and accompanied by an AI Disclosure Statement detailing the prompt used and the nature of assistance received.
- **Unauthorized AI Use:** Submitting AI-generated content as original student work without teacher approval or proper citation constitutes academic dishonesty and plagiarism.

Data Privacy in AI

Students and staff are strictly prohibited from inputting Personally Identifiable Information (PII), confidential school records, or proprietary assignments into non-enterprise or public AI models.

10. Acceptable Use of Technology

School technology resources are provided primarily for educational and administrative purposes.

- **Permitted Activities:** Curriculum research, educational collaboration, academic creation, and authorized school communication.
 - **Prohibited Activities:** Modifying system settings, attempting to bypass content filters or proxies, downloading pirated software/media, running unauthorized scripts, engaging in commercial activities, or sharing account credentials.
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11. Online Learning Expectations

During synchronous or asynchronous remote/hybrid learning sessions, the following standards apply:

- Video cameras should be turned on during instruction unless an exemption has been approved by the teacher.
 - Students must join virtual sessions using official school-provided email accounts and display their full name.
 - Chat functions, interactive whiteboards, and breakout rooms are reserved exclusively for lesson-related discussions.
 - Recording, photographing, or screenshotting virtual classes without express consent from the teacher and participants is strictly prohibited.
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12. Data Privacy and Information Security

The school complies with rigorous data protection standards to safeguard student and staff records:

- **Data Minimization:** Collecting only data necessary for educational operations and student growth tracking.
 - **Third-Party Vetting:** All digital software, applications, and cloud platforms utilized in instruction must undergo strict privacy reviews to confirm compliance with students safety standards prior to classroom deployment.
 - **Secure Storage:** Encrypted databases for student records, health information, and assessment results with strict access logs.
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13. Cyberbullying Prevention

Cyberbullying is defined as any willful, repeated, and harmful act committed through digital channels (including social media, messaging apps, gaming platforms, or email). The school maintains a zero-tolerance stance toward online bullying, harassment, intimidation, or exclusion.

- **Proactive Measures:** Regular socio-emotional learning workshops, peer advocacy programs, and anti-bullying awareness weeks.
 - **Disciplinary & Restorative Process:** Reported incidents will be promptly investigated. Consequences range from counseling and parental conferences to privilege suspension, restorative mediation, or formal disciplinary action depending on severity.
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14. Digital Wellbeing

To promote health, balance, and cognitive wellbeing, the school advocates healthy tech practices:

- **Screen-Free Zones & Breaks:** Scheduled device-free five minute breaks between sessions and 30 minute lunch break.
 - **Ergonomics & Eye Care:** Instruction on proper posture, screen distance, and the 20-20-20 visual rest rule.
 - **Homework Screen Limits:** Faculty guidelines to ensure balanced homework assignments that do not demand excessive screen time.
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15. Reporting Cyber Safety Concerns

Prompt reporting is crucial for maintaining community safety. Reports can be submitted through the following channels:

- Direct notification through email or gchat message to Home Room Teacher, Counselor, or School Administrator.

All reports will be treated with appropriate confidentiality, and retaliatory actions against reporters will strictly result in disciplinary sanctions.

16. Monitoring and Review

To maintain network integrity and ensure user safety, the school reserves the right to monitor and log network traffic, internet searches, bandwidth consumption, and stored files on school-owned systems and accounts. Users should have no expectation of privacy when using school networks or school-provided accounts.

17. Training and Awareness

- **Staff Professional Learning:** Annual mandatory training on cybersecurity awareness, data privacy compliance, AI integration, and identifying online threats.
- **Student Orientation:** Grade-appropriate digital citizenship and cyber safety modules delivered at the start of each academic term.
- **Parent Workshops:** Regular informational webinars on supporting online safety, managing screen time, and understanding emerging AI technologies at home.
- **Global Clubs:** Activities related to cybersafety, AI and digital wellbeing are conducted during Tech clubs and ICT sessions.